One hundred sappers had accompanied the force ‘for the express purpose of raising a *sangar* [shallow trenches and breastworks] behind which our troops would have been wholly protected from the fire of the jezails, and infused into our troops a sense of security . . . But no such defence was raised.’[75] Instead, exposed on the brow of the hill, rank after rank fell where they stood, as Shelton remained rigid and unmoving under fire, astonishingly brave but fatally unimaginative, apparently unable to think of any response to the destruction of his regiment.

To add to their misfortunes, Shelton’s one gun had now over-heated and was unable to reply to the Afghan jezails. Among those wounded at this point was Vincent Eyre, who received a bullet through his left hand ‘which for the present terminated my active services’, and Colin Mackenzie, who took a bullet in the left shoulder. ‘Three times the face of the square had to be made up,’ Mackenzie wrote afterwards.

> The front ranks had been literally mowed away . . . Our ammunition was almost expended and by one pm the men were faint from fatigue and thirst. But no water was procurable and the number of killed and wounded was swelled every instant. I tried to persuade Shelton to effect a retreat only to be told: ‘Oh no, we will hold the hill some time longer.’ On Shelton’s refusal to retire, Colonel Oliver, who was a very stout man, remarked that the inevitable result would be a general flight to cantonments, and that, as he was too unwieldy to run, the sooner he got shot the better. He then exposed himself to the enemy’s fire and fell mortally wounded.[76]

To the growing horror of Lady Sale and the other spectators watching from the cantonment rooftops – ‘I had a fine view of the field of action, and by keeping behind the chimneys, escaped the bullets that continually whizzed past me’ – a large party of Afghan ghazis led personally by Abdullah Khan now began to crawl up a hidden gully towards the squares, out of sight of the infantry, but clearly visible to the ladies.[77] Moments later they broke cover and flung themselves at the redcoats. According to the *Tarikh-i-Sultani*, ‘at that moment, Abdullah Khan Achakzai, who was renowned for his bravery and had included a wish for martyrdom in his early morning prayers, yelled, “With Allah’s grace, Victory indeed is near!” and with his unit launched an assault like a fierce lion or the serpent that inhabits the scented grass. He captured the English cannon and pushed back the British infantry soldiers, dispersing them. The British soldiers couldn’t withstand this assault and turned and fled.’[78]

Within minutes the nearest square had collapsed, and the Afghans began to drag away the captured gun. ‘It was very like the scenes depicted in the